

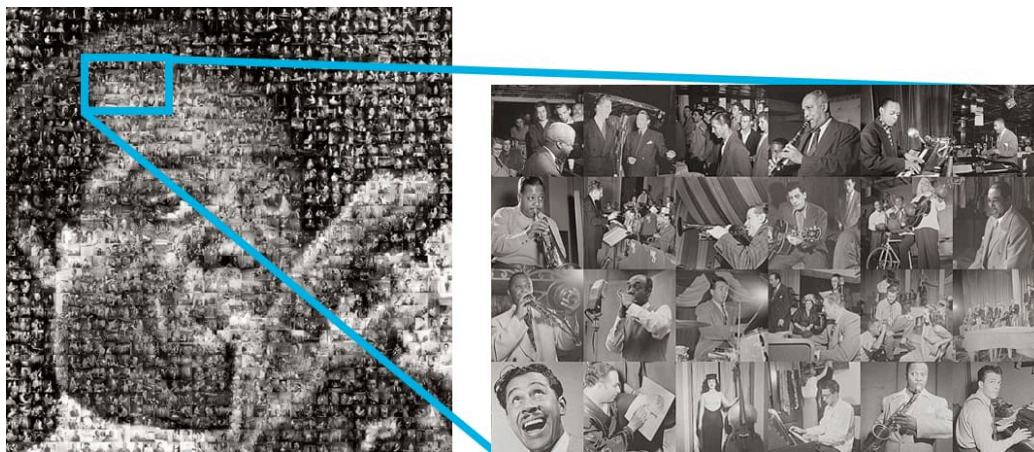
Session 4: Pieces and Patterns in Biblical Narrative

Key Takeaways

- The Bible is like a photo mosaic with identifiable smaller literary units crafted and arranged to work together and create a larger, overarching message.
- Biblical authors use repeated scenes, often with slight variations, to develop themes throughout the story.

Design Patterns and Literary Analysis

Recall our earlier exploration of the origins of the Hebrew Bible. It's a collection of collections that has been written, adapted, and edited into a unified whole. Consider two additional analogies that will help us understand the significance of this fact for how we read and interpret biblical literature.



Silvers, Robert (2000). *Louis Armstrong*. Photomosaic.com.

The unique unity of the larger photo mosaic is achieved precisely by its composite nature. The thematic arrangement of light/dark/great tiny squares becomes a tool to create larger patterns of color that provide an ordered, unified picture of the subject. The Hebrew Bible displays this kind of mosaic unity on a large and small scale.

Analogy 2: Repeated Motifs and Themes in Film

Movie directors often create a cohesive unity to the themes and plot line of a story by repetition and variation. By building up viewer expectations through repetition, the artist can introduce variation and surprise.

One example of this is the motif of the ring temptation scene in *The Lord of the Rings*. Some characters are tempted by the ring's power, and they succumb to it (Smeagol, Boromir, Frodo). Other characters resist its

power but in different ways (Bilbo, barely, Gandalf and Galadriel, through fear and trembling, and Aragorn, like it's no problem!). This diverse set of responses to the ring's power creates a rich palette of characters and a complex portrait of power in the story.



Jackson, P. (Director). (2001-2003). *The Lord of the Rings Series* [Film]. New Line Cinema.

The biblical authors were masters of this technique. In fact, this basic principle of patterned repetition and analogy is the most fundamental tool in their repertoire. And it's accomplished through the simplest of means: strategic repetition of key words.

Reading Strategies Based on Analogies

These two analogies illustrate different features of the TaNaK collection that create the need for two related reading strategies.

1. Identifying literary units: Just as a photo mosaic consists of hundreds of smaller photos, the epic biblical narrative consists of hundreds of smaller episodes. Learn to identify the beginning and ending of literary units that make up the larger mosaic of a biblical book.
2. Identifying repeated words and themes: Just as the smaller photos in a photo mosaic are organized according to patterns of color, light, and tone, the literary units of the biblical narrative are woven together through patterns of repeated words, themes, and images. These repetitions invite the reader to see continuity and an ongoing argument that develops throughout the course of the story.

Applying the Strategies to the Eden Narrative

When all the above principles are applied to a literary analysis, it yields the following outline of the Eden narrative.

Verses	Unit	Part	Movement
2:4-6 No garden, humans, or rain	2:4-17 From Wasteland to Eden	2:4-25 From Isolated Wasteland to Communion in Eden	2:4-3:24 The Eden Narrative: From Garden to Exile
2:7-9 God plants a garden and forms human			
2:10-14 The Eden river flows to become four rivers			
2:15-17 Human put in the garden + divine command			
2:18-20 Problem: a human alone	2:18-25 From Isolation to Communion		
2:21-23 Solution: two humans out of one			
2:24-25 Two humans married			
3:1-5 Dialogue between snake and woman	3:1-13 Folly and the Fall		
3:6-7 Woman and man eat from the tree			
3:8-13 Dialogue between God and humans			
3:14-15 Curse on the snake	3:14-24 The Fallout	3:14-24 The Fallout and Exile from Eden	
3:16 Consequences for the woman			
3:17-19 Consequences for the man			
3:20-21 Provision of garments			
3:22-24 Humans exiled from Eden			
Identifying the Literary Units of Genesis 2-3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).			

Reflection Question

Tim uses two analogies to show us some important Bible study skills. What can the photo mosaic help us pay attention to? What about the ring temptations from The Lord of the Rings?